might not have been better if they had waited and not moved so soon. I understood and sympathized with them, as anyone would, but I knew there were people in their government trying slowly to increase democracy and freedom in China, and the students' revolt, as courageous as it was, might in the long run have made it more difficult for them to carry out what they were trying to do.

As I say, the future is hard to predict in China, although I'm still betting on the triumph there of the tidal wave of freedom that is sweeping across our world.

A few weeks after we got back from China, I left for the economic summit in London, making along the way two unforgettable stopovers.

In Ireland, we helicoptered to the village of Ballyporeen in County Tipperary. It was from here that my great-grandfather, Michael Reagan, had left for America during the middle of the nineteenth century, at a time of great hardship in his homeland. My father had been orphaned before he was six, and neither he nor I had ever known much about Jack's side of the family. But presidents sometimes enjoy pleasant perks, and for the occasion of our visit, the Irish government had dug up our roots and introduced me to them.

In Ballyporeen, a priest showed me the handwritten entry recording the baptism of Michael Reagan in 1829, then we crossed a street to the church where his baptism had taken place. Next, I walked through the town where he grew up, shaking hands with as many people as I could, on the way to a pub that had been named after me. There, I quaffed a beer and was presented with a copy of my family tree researched by Burke's Peerage; it showed that I was distantly related not only to Queen Elizabeth II, but also to John F. Kennedy.

At a reception in the pub, our hosts told me they had invited several of my distant relatives, including one who